

Cherry Blossoms Connecting the U.S. and Japan



It has been more than 100 years since Japanese cherry trees were planted along the banks of the Potomac in Washington, DC and the Hudson in New York in 1912. Approximately 3,000 cherry trees were donated. These are symbol of friendship between the U.S. and Japan.



The Beginning of the Cherry Blossom Planting Project

Almost 117 years ago, on April 7, 1909, a letter from the White House was received by an American woman, Eliza R. Scidmore. She was the first woman to serve on the board of directors of the National Geographic Society.



Sidmore visited Japan several times and was fascinated by the beauty of Japanese cherry blossoms. And she sent a letter to the then first lady asking her to plant Japanese cherry trees on the Potomac River in Washington.



The first lady, Helen Herron Taft

The first donation of 2,000 cherry tree saplings arrived in Washington the following year, but were all burned due to pest damage.



Arrival of Cherry Trees to DC
Courtesy of U.S. National Arboretum



Burning of diseased Cherry Trees
Courtesy of U.S. National Arboretum

Therefore, in 1912, 3,020 cherry tree saplings were presented again, arrived safely, and a tree-planting ceremony was held on March 27 of the same year by President Taft's wife and the wife of the U.S. ambassador at the time.



Not only is it loved by citizens as a symbol of the capital city, but it is also popular among tourists from all over the U.S. Many people enjoy eating and taking pictures under the cherry trees.



さくらもち Sakura Mochi

Sakura mochi is pink-colored mochi, which gives it the soft pink flush like the flower it's named after, stuffed with red bean paste and wrapped in a sakura leaf. The leaf is edible, and it'll add a really refreshing salty element to the otherwise sweet mochi.



Sakura-themed wagashi sweets

This delicate pastry is filled with centuries of Japanese culture. The cherry blossom-themed wagashi is very beautiful.



Ichigo Daifuku (Strawberry Mochi)

Another rice cake confectionery and a springtime staple is “Ichigo Daifuku” (Strawberry Daifuku). Strawberries in Japan are harvested weeks (sometimes months) earlier than in other regions. For this reason, strawberry mochi can be found everywhere in spring.



Starbucks' Cherry Blossom Drinks

Starbucks Japan never disappoints with its seasonal. From cappuccinos to iced tea, every year sees a limited selection of sakura-flavored and sakura-inspired drinks available only at this time of year.



たけのこ Takenoko (Bamboo Shoots)

Takenoko, or bamboo shoots, is also one of spring's conspicuous grocery store ingredients. Takenoko is usually eaten with rice; its delicate and earthy smell immediately amps your appetite.

